

Primary Source Reading 2: Habituation and the Doctrine of the Mean

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book II, translated by W. D. Ross (1908) Read before Lesson 15b: Virtue and the Formation of Character

Before you read: Aristotle asks how the virtues are acquired, and gives an answer that runs against the Socratic assumption that virtue is a kind of knowledge. As you read, notice the comparison to learning a craft — and then follow how the same idea about habituation leads Aristotle to his famous doctrine of the mean.

We Become Just by Doing Just Acts

Of all the things that come to us by nature we first acquire the potentiality and later exhibit the activity... but the virtues we get by first exercising them, as also happens in the case of the arts as well. For the things we have to learn before we can do them, we learn by doing them, e.g. men become builders by building and lyre-players by playing the lyre; so too we become just by doing just acts, temperate by doing temperate acts, brave by doing brave acts.

This is confirmed by what happens in states; for legislators make the citizens good by forming habits in them, and this is the wish of every legislator, and those who do not effect it miss their mark.

States of Character Arise from Like Activities

Again, it is from the same causes and by the same means that every virtue is both produced and destroyed, and similarly every art; for it is from playing the lyre that both good and bad lyre-players are produced... This, then, is the case with the virtues also; by doing the acts that we do in our transactions with other men we become just or unjust, and by doing the acts that we do in the presence of danger, and being habituated to feel fear or confidence, we become brave or cowardly. The same is true of appetites and feelings of anger; some men become temperate and good-tempered, others self-indulgent and irascible, by behaving in one way or the other in the appropriate circumstances. Thus, in one word, states of character arise out of like activities.

Virtue as a Mean

If it is thus, then, that every art does its work well — by looking to the intermediate and judging its works by this standard... and if, further, virtue is more exact and better than any art, as nature also is, then virtue must have the quality of aiming at the intermediate. I mean moral virtue; for it is this that is concerned with passions and actions, and in these there is excess, defect, and the intermediate. For instance, both fear and confidence and appetite and anger and pity and in general pleasure and

pain may be felt both too much and too little, and in both cases not well; but to feel them at the right times, with reference to the right objects, towards the right people, with the right motive, and in the right way, is what is both intermediate and best, and this is characteristic of virtue.

The Mean Relative to Us

Virtue, then, is a state of character concerned with choice, lying in a mean, i.e. the mean relative to us, this being determined by a rational principle, and by that principle by which the man of practical wisdom would determine it. Now it is a mean between two vices, that which depends on excess and that which depends on defect.

After you read: Notice that Aristotle's mean is not a fixed arithmetic midpoint — it is “relative to us,” fixed by the judgment of a person with practical wisdom, not by a formula that could be applied the same way in every case. As you read the lesson, watch for how this idea — virtue as a trained, situational sensitivity rather than a rule — connects back to the claim that opened this reading: that we become virtuous the same way we become skilled at a craft, by doing the thing, repeatedly, until it becomes second nature.